These parties grew stronger day by day, opened their centres and madrasahs, exerted to propel their sectarian viewpoint, influenced the successive governments and even challenged the system and the constitution. There were only 30 religious parties in Pakistan that belonged to Deobandi (7), Barelvi (5), Ahl-e-Hadith (4) and Shi'a (3) parties in 1979, which increased to 237 in 2010.

A few prominent jihadi organisations, many of whose members turned into militants and extremists supporting Taliban, TTP and Al Qaeda, were Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami (HuJI), Jamaat-ud-Dawa (JuD) or Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) and Jaish-e-Muhammad (JeM).

HARKAT-UL-JIHAD-AL-ISLAMI (HuJI)

Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami, commonly known as HuJI, was a Pakistan-based militant organisation. In 1980, it was floated as Jamiat Ansarul Afghaneen (the Party of the Friends of Afghan People). It was one of the first organisations created to fight the soviets in Afghanistan. Later, the group changed its name and turned its focus towards India in Kashmir after the Jihad with the Soviets was over in the late 1980s. The group expanded its operational area from the Kashmir theatre to regional states. It was also believed that HuJI operated in regional states like Chechnya, Uzbekistan and Sinkiang, China and even Bangladesh (Rana, 2009).

After the US invasion of Afghanistan in 2001 and the subsequent ousting of the Taliban, HuJI shifted its base from Afghanistan and many of its leaders sneaked into Pakistan and settled in the South Waziristan Agency of Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA). Many of its activists also made their way to the north in the central Asian region to escape killing or capture by the US or Northern Alliance forces. However, a majority of the activists preferred to settle in FATA.

Qari Saifullah Akhtar was one of the few Jihadi leaders from Pakistan who escaped with Taliban Ameer Mullah Omar from the forays of US-led allied forces in October 2001. He first took shelter in South Waziristan, then moved to Peshawar and eventually fled to Saudi Arabia, from where he decided to move to the UAE (Mir, 2008). He was later arrested in the UAE and handed over to Pakistani authorities in 2004. He was detained by the security forces on the charges of anti-state activities inside and outside Pakistan. He was released in September 2007 but was again arrested in February 2008 after Benazir Bhutto,